

GREEN AND CLEAN
A groom and his *baraat* arrive on cycles for a sustainable wedding

Hi-Tech Nuptials

Wedtech apps have made wedding planning not just safer but also more convenient. Here are some of the top apps for those about to tie the knot

WEDMEGOOD
Founded in 2014
A one-stop shop, the app can help you create wedding invitations and choose your vendors. The app has seen a monthly download of over 75,000 and 3 million total users.

RSVP MANAGER
Founded in 2020
The app helps users manage guest logistics–track their arrival and departure, meal preferences. The app needs to be bought from WeddingWishlist. It has over 1,000 users.

APPY COUPLE
Founded in 2011
Appy allows couples to design and customise their own wedding app and website. The website has about 129,452 monthly visits and saw 1,998 app downloads over the past 30 days.

WEDDING PLANNER BY WEDDINGWIRE
Founded in 2017
It connects couples and their families with local wedding professionals. It has over 500,000 users and over a million downloads.

instances of couples opting for "green" or "zero-waste" weddings, with the bride and groom sending guests home with saplings to plant in their own homes. This need for sustainability is another reason why hybrid weddings have taken off. According to Kanika Subbiah, founder, Wedding Wishlist, an online wedding planning company, "The pandemic may have been a significant factor in the meteoric rise of virtual weddings, but celebrations in India would have gotten here eventually even without Covid. Virtual weddings are cost-effective, better for the environment, easier to organise and more intimate."

The industry is adapting on the fly. WeddingWire India, a wedding planning app and part of The Knot Worldwide, has partnered with matchmaking portal Shaadi.com as their official vendor partner to launch their WeddingsFromHome campaign.

Technology has played a huge part in the survival of the wedding industry. "Wedtech is affordable, accessible and helps ease communication—physical cards are no good in a world where circumstances and wedding plans change often," says Subbiah. With the use of technology, couples can communicate better with their guests. It has also helped them shortlist venues via virtual tours, find vendors, make-up artists and mehndi-walas, among other services.

"Wedtech apps are on the verge of becoming a crucial part of the mainstream wedding culture in India," says Anam Zubair, associate director of marketing, WeddingWire India. As per WeddingWire statistics, there were around 250,000-300,000 couples in India using the internet to find wedding vendors in 2020 itself.

A STEP INTO THE FUTURE

In the final quarter of 2021, as the Delta wave receded, a positive movement in the industry was visible as weddings resumed. The first '*maha saya*' (auspicious period) on November 21 saw 8,000 weddings held in one day in just Delhi itself. As per estimates by the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT), around 2.5 million weddings took place in November and December. "On our platform, we witnessed a surge of 57 per cent in November 2021 compared to the same period in the previous year," says Zubair. They are, in fact, seeing a significant demand for the upcoming summer wedding season, between April 17 and July 22, with 58 per cent of *mahurat* dates of the year falling in this period.

Interestingly, many couples are opting for 'non-*saaya*' dates. Statistics gathered by WeddingWire India reveal a 76 per cent surge in demand for such dates in the first half of 2022 compared to the previous year. Bengaluru has the most demand for non-*saaya* weddings at 16 per cent, Mumbai follows at 12 per cent and Jaipur, 11 per cent.

The pandemic might have altered the wedding industry forever, bringing in changes that are most definitely here to stay, according to industry experts. But will the Indian wedding no longer be big and fat? "No! We don't think the wedding industry will be 'slim or trim'. The majority of the population still wants to get married with all their family and friends by their side," says Zubair. The year 2022 might just be one of resurgence for the industry. ■